

A Choice That Has a Cost: A Better Question

有代价的选择：更好的问题

Theme: 心理、决策、责任与人生选择 · New: 44 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 44/6,127

English Story

The better question came out of a long argument about **authority**: who has the right to make a **decision** that will outlive the person who makes it? “We **think** about the **election** and not about the ten years after it,” the chair said. “A **ruling** that nobody can revise is not a **rule**; it is a **veto** on the future.”

The **sense of** the room was that the **past** had been treated as a **guarantee**. “Our **planning** has been built on one **assumption**, and the **assumption** is a **fashion**,” Maya wrote. “We are **responsible** for a **selection of** facts, not for all of them, and the **waste** is in the ones we discarded.”

The **hearing** produced a **representation of** the **risk** that nobody had prepared for: a **variable** that was treated as **secondary**, and a **hedge** that had become the whole **venture**. “Be **conscious of** the **motivation** behind a number,” the auditor said. “A **coherent** report can still be a **rude** one.”

The **abstract** part of the question was the hardest: what kind of **thinking** do we reward? A **cue** from the **dial**, an **inspiration** from the **sole** survivor of the last flood, and a **decision** made in **peril**: the room had a dozen answers and no method for choosing between them.

“Do not **speculate** about the dead,” the boatman said. “Consider the living.” The **daring** part of the proposal was to publish the disagreement itself, with the **condensation of** six months of argument on a single page, and the careful record of who had said what.

Therefore the better question was not what the group should decide, but who should be able to revise it. The price of that question was high, the good and the bad answers would both be carried forward, and the moment had arrived to write it down. Against the history of the valley, the value of a **selective** record was the only thing we could **find**. The **mind** does not die with an author, and then the archive must answer for itself; the **sole** and the **ruling** were the same word in a different **sense**. We had to **find** a way to keep the **mind of** the project alive after its authors moved on.

中文翻译

那个更好的问题出在一场关于权威的漫长争论里：谁有权做出一个将比做决定的人活得更久的决定？“我们想的是选举，而不是它之后的十年，”主席说，“一项没人能修订的裁定不是规则；它是对未来的否决权。”

屋里的感觉是：过去一直被当作一份担保。“我们的规划建立在一个假定之上，而这个假定是一种时尚，”曼雅写道，“我们只对一部分事实负责，而不是全部，浪费就在我们丢弃的那些里。”

听证会产出了一份没人准备好的风险陈述：一个被当作次要的变量，以及一道已经变成整笔冒险的对冲。“要意识到一个数字背后的动机，”审计员说，“一份连贯的报告仍然可能是一份粗鲁的报告。”

这个问题抽象的部分最难：我们奖励的是哪种思考？刻度盘上的一个提示、来自上一场洪水唯一幸存者的灵感，以及在险境中做出的一个决定：屋里有十几种答案，却没有在它们之间做选择的方法。

“不要揣测死者，”船夫说，“考虑活着的人。”这份提案的大胆之处在于把分歧本身公布出来，把六个月的争论浓缩在一页纸上，并仔细记录谁说了什么。

因此，更好的问题不是小组该决定什么，而是谁应当有权修订它。这个问题的代价很高，好的和坏的答案都会被带向未来，而写下它的时刻已经到了。与这个山谷的历史相对照，一份有选择的记录的价值，是我们唯一能找到的东西。心智不会随着作者死去，而此后档案必须为自己作答；唯一与裁定，是同一个词在不同意义上的用法。我们必须找到一种办法，让这个项目的心智在它的作者们离开之后继续活着。

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
think θɪŋk POS: vt	vt. 想, 考虑, 想起, 想像, 打算, 认为; vi. 思考, 料想; n. 想法; a. 思想的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an instance of deliberate thinking; v. judge or regard; look upon; judge; v. expect, believe, or suppose; v. ...
out aʊt POS: a	a. 外面的, 熄灭的, 结束的; adv. 在外, 熄灭, 出现; prep. 出自, 离去, 向 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (baseball) a failure by a batter or runner to reach a base safely in baseball; v. reveal (something) about...
find faɪnd POS: vt	vt. 发现, 感到, 找到, 认为, 得到; vi. 裁决; n. 发现; [计] 查找; DOS外部命令: 在指定的文件或从键盘输入的文本行中... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. come upon, as if by accident; meet with; v. come upon after searching; find the location of something that...
live lɪv, laɪv POS: a	a. 活的, 生动的, 精力充沛的, 实况转播的; vi. 活, 生存, 居住; vt. 过着, 度过, 经历; adv. 实地地 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. lead a certain kind of life; live in a certain style; v. pursue a positive and satisfying existence; a. actu...
authority ɔ:'θɒrɪtɪ POS: n	n. 权力, 当权者, 当局, 权威, 专家; [经] 代理权, 授权, 权威 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the power or right to give orders or make decisions; n. (usually plural) persons who exercise (administrati...
decision dɪ'sɪʒən POS: n	n. 决定, 决心, 决断; [计] 判定 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of making up your mind about something; n. a position or opinion or judgment reached after consider...
mind maɪnd POS: n	n. 思想, 愿望, 智力, 记忆, 心理, 情绪, 理智, 主意, 心意; vi. 介意, 注意, 留心; vt. 注意, 留意, 专心于, ... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. that which is responsible for one's thoughts and feelings; the seat of the faculty of reason; n. recall or...
sense sens POS: n	n. 感应, 感觉, 感官, 意识, 观念, 情理, 知觉, 理智; vt. 感觉, 觉察, 检测; [计] 阅读; 检测 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a general conscious awareness; n. the meaning of a word or expression; the way in which a word or expressio...
rule ru:l POS: n	n. 规则, 统治, 控制, 支配, 规律, 标准, 章程, 破折号, 铅线; vt. 规定, 统治, 管理, 控制, 支配, 裁决; vi. ... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a principle or condition that customarily governs behavior; n. prescribed guide for conduct or action; n. (l...
election ɪ'lekʃən POS: n	n. 选举, 当选, 选择权; [法] 选举, 当选 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a vote to select the winner of a position or political office; n. the act of selecting someone or something...
risk rɪsk POS: n	n. 冒险, 危险, 保险额; vt. 冒...的危险, 冒险干 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a venture undertaken without regard to possible loss or injury; n. the probability of becoming infected giv...
past pɑ:st POS: n	n. 过去, 昔时, 往事, 早年经历, 过去时; a. 过去的, 结束的, 卸任的, 过去时的; prep. 越过, 晚于, 超越, 超出... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the time that has elapsed; n. a earlier period in someone's life (especially one that they have reason to k...
prepare prɪ'peə POS: vt	vt. 准备, 筹备, 使在思想上有准备, 制造, 调制; vi. 预备 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. to prepare verbally, either for written or spoken delivery; v. educate for a future role or function; v. lea...
planning phonetic unavailable POS: n	n. 计划的制订, 策划, 设计, 规划; [计] 计划, 规划 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an act of formulating a program for a definite course of action; n. the act or process of drawing up plans...
responsible rɪ'spɒnsəbl POS: a	a. 有责任的, 负责的, 责任重大的; [法] 应负责任的, 有责任的, 能履行责任的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. worthy of or requiring responsibility or trust; or held accountable; s. being the agent or cause
selection sɪ'lekʃən POS: n	n. 选择, 选文, 精选品; [医] 选择, 淘汰 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an assortment of things from which a choice can be made
waste weɪst POS: n	n. 浪费, 废物, 损耗, 消耗, 荒地, 垃圾, 地面风化物; a. 废弃的, 荒芜的, 多余的; vt. 浪费, 消耗, 使荒芜; vi. ... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any materials unused and rejected as worthless or unwanted; n. useless or profitless activity; using or exp...
assumption ə'sʌmpʃən POS: n	n. 假定, 自负, 担任, 假装; [经] 假定, 承担 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a hypothesis that is taken for granted; n. the act of taking possession of or power over something; n. celeb...
thinking 'θɪŋkɪŋ POS: n	n. 思考, 思想; a. 思考的, 有理性的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the process of using your mind to consider something carefully

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
hearing 'hiəriŋ POS: n	n. 听, 听觉, 听讯; [医] 听, 听觉 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (law) a proceeding (usually by a court) where evidence is taken for the purpose of determining an issue of...
representation ,reprɪzən'teɪʃən POS: n	n. 表示法, 表现, 陈述, 代表; [计] 表示法指定 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a presentation to the mind in the form of an idea or image; n. a creation that is a visual or tangible rend...
fashion 'fæʃən POS: n	n. 流行, 风尚, 时样; vt. 形成, 造, 作 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. characteristic or habitual practice; n. the latest and most admired style in clothes and cosmetics and beha...
variable 'veəriəbl POS: n	n. 易变的事物, 变数, 可变物, 变量; a. 可变的, 不定的, 易变的, 变量的; [计] 变量 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. something that is likely to vary; something that is subject to variation; n. a quantity that can assume any...
secondary 'sekəndəri POS: a	a. 中级的, 中等的, 次要的, 第二的, 从属的, 辅助的; [化] 仲(指CH-3...CH(CH-3)-型支链烃基或指二元胺及R-2... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the defensive football players who line up behind the linemen; a. being of second rank or importance or val...
guarantee ,gæərən'ti: POS: n	n. 担保, 抵押品, 保证书; vt. 保证, 担保 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a written assurance that some product or service will be provided or will meet certain specifications; n. a...
conscious 'kɒnʃəs POS: a	a. 有意识的, 知觉的, 觉察的; [医] 有意识的, 清醒的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. intentionally conceived; a. knowing and perceiving; having awareness of surroundings and sensations and tho...
venture 'ventʃə POS: n	n. 冒险, 风险; vt. 敢于, 冒...的危险; vi. 冒险 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any venturesome undertaking especially one with an uncertain outcome; n. a commercial undertaking that risk...
motivation ,məʊti'veɪʃən POS: n	n. 动机, 刺激, 推动; [医] 促动, 推动, 诱导 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the psychological feature that arouses an organism to action toward a desired goal; the reason for the act...
sole seʊl POS: n	n. 脚掌, 鞋底, 底部; a. 唯一的, 仅有的, 单独的, 独身的; vt. 上鞋底, 触底 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the underside of footwear or a golf club; n. lean flesh of any of several flatfish; n. the underside of the...
ruling 'ru:lɪŋ POS: n	n. 判决, 裁定, 统治; a. 统治的, 支配的, 普遍的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n the reason for a court's judgment (as opposed to the decision itself); v exercise authority over; as of nati...
abstract 'æbstrækt POS: a	a. 抽象的, 深奥的; n. 摘要, 抽象概念; vt. 摘要, 提炼, 使抽象化; [计] 摘录; 摘要; 抽象 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. consider a concept without thinking of a specific example; consider abstractly or theoretically; v. conside...
inspiration ,ɪnspə'reɪʃən POS: n	n. 灵感, 鼓舞人心的人或物, 妙计, 吸气; [医] 吸[气] Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. arousal of the mind to special unusual activity or creativity; n. a product of your creative thinking and w...
hedge hedʒ POS: n	n. 树篱, 障碍, 套头交易; vt. 用树篱围, 套期保值, 妨碍, 两面下注以防...的损失; vi. 筑树篱, 躲闪, 两面下注以防损... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a fence formed by a row of closely planted shrubs or bushes; n. any technique designed to reduce or elimina...
speculate 'spekjuleɪt POS: vi	vi. 深思, 推测, 投机; [经] 投机 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. to believe especially on uncertain or tentative grounds; v. talk over conjecturally, or review in an idle o...
selective sɪ'lektɪv POS: a	a. 选择的, 选择性的; [经] 选择的, 选择性的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. tending to select; characterized by careful choice; s. characterized by very careful or fastidious selection
cue kju: POS: n	n. 提示, 线索; vt. 给...暗示(或提示); [计] 尾接指令 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an actor's line that immediately precedes and serves as a reminder for some action or speech; n. sports imp...
considering kən'sɪdərɪŋ POS: prep	prep. 就...而论; conj. 考虑到 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v deem to be; v give careful consideration to; v take into consideration for exemplifying purposes; v show consi...
coherent kəʊ'hɪərənt POS: a	a. 互相耦合的, 清晰的, 明了的, 凝聚性的, 连贯的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. marked by an orderly, logical, and aesthetically consistent relation of parts; s. capable of thinking and e...
rude ru:d POS: a	a. 粗鲁无礼的, 粗陋的, 粗暴的, 原始的, 未开化的, 大略的, 崎岖不平的, 狂暴的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s socially incorrect in behavior; s (of persons) lacking in refinement or grace; a lacking civility or good man...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
dial 'daɪəl POS: n	n. 刻度盘, 钟面, 转盘; v. 拨 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the face of a timepiece; graduated to show the hours; n. the control on a radio or television set that is u...
veto 'vi:təʊ POS: n	n. 否决权; vt. 否决, 禁止 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a vote that blocks a decision; n. the power or right to prohibit or reject a proposed or intended act (espe...
peril 'perɪl POS: n	n. 危险, 冒...之险, 险境, 险因; vt. 置...于险境, 冒险, 危及 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n a source of danger; a possibility of incurring loss or misfortune; n a state of danger involving risk; n a ve...
daring 'deərɪŋ POS: a	a. 大胆的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n a challenge to do something dangerous or foolhardy; n the trait of being willing to undertake things that in...
condensation 'kɒndən'seɪʃən POS: n	n. 压缩, 凝缩, 冷凝; [化] 冷凝; 冷凝作用; 缩合; 缩合作用; 凝聚; 凝聚作用; 凝结作用 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (psychoanalysis) an unconscious process whereby two ideas or images combine into a single symbol; especial...